Autopsy Room Four

By Stephen King

HOWARD: **(Pg 19-44)** It's so dark that for a while, I think I'm still unconscious. Then, slowly, it comes to me that unconscious people don't have a sensation of movement through the dark, accompanied by a faint, rhythmic sound that can only be a squeaky wheel. And I can feel contact from the top of my head to the balls of my heels. This is not unconsciousness, and there is something too… too rational about the sensations from it to be a dream. Then what is it? What's happening to me? The squeaky wheel quits its stupid rhythm and I stop moving. ***What's going on here?*** I yell, but the yell is only in my head. My lips don't move. I can feel them, but I can't move them.

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INTRODUCTION

Alfred Hitchcock was a master of mystery and suspense. In 1955 he launched a television episode to rival The Twilight Zone. The plot of Breakdown went something like this: William Callew, a hard-nosed and hard-hearted businessman who holds in contempt such human failings as sentiment, pity, and tears. While racing to keep an appointment in New York, Callew is involved in a spectacular car accident. Awakening, he finds that he is completely paralyzed, unable to move or speak -- though we hear his every thought on the soundtrack. Everyone who comes across Callew assumes that he is dead, including the police and the coroner...and as the episode draws to its conclusion, the horrified Callew is being wheeled into the autopsy room of the morgue!

But that could never happen in real life – or could it? Autopsy Room Four by Stephen King.

HOWARD: I'm grabbed, shoulders and calves, and lifted. I'm swung through the air in an envelope of blackness- ***Hey, don't drop me, I've got a bad back!*** I try to say, and again, there's no movement of the lips or teeth. What if I'm dead? What if this is what death is like? It fits. The dark, the rubbery smell. Nowadays I am Howard the Conqueror, stockbroker *extraordinaire,*

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terror of Derry Municipal Country Club, frequent *habitué* of what is known at golf courses all over the world as the Nineteenth Hole, but in '71 I was part of a Medical Assistance Team in the Mekong Delta, a scared kid who sometimes woke up wet-eyed from dreams of the family dog, and all at once I know this feel, this smell. Dear God, I'm in a body bag.

ORDERLY: Want to sign this, doc? Remember to bear down hard-it's three copies.

HOWARD: Sound of a pen, scraping away on paper. I imagine the owner of the first voice holding out a clipboard to the doctor. ***Oh dear Jesus let me not be dead!*** I try to scream, and nothing comes out. I'm breathing though… aren't I? I mean, I can't feel myself doing it, but my lungs seem okay, they're not throbbing or yelling for air the way they do when you've swum too far underwater, so I must be okay, right?

There's a harsh ripping sound and all at once I am in white light; it is blinding, like the sun breaking through a scrim of clouds on a winter day. I try to squint my eyes shut against it, but nothing happens. My eyelids are like

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blinds on broken rollers. A face bends over me, blocking off part of my glare.

Help me! But I can only look up into his dark blue eyes with my frozen dead man's stare. If I'm still alive, how come he hasn't seen my pupil's contract when the light hit them? But I know the answer to that… or I think I do. They didn't contract. That's why the glare from the fluorescents is so painful.

Soft shoes squeaking on tile, and suddenly that sound is replaced by the sound of my driver, beating the bush for my ball. I hate fourteen, supposedly there's poison ivy, and with all this underbrush, there could easily be. And then something bit me, didn't it? Yes, I'm almost sure it did. On the left calf, just above the top of my sock. A red-hot darning needle of pain, perfectly concentrated at first, then spreading…

…Then darkness. Until the gurney, zipped up snug inside a body bag.

I want to think it was some kind of snake, but maybe that's only because I was thinking about them while I hunted for my ball. It could have been an insect, I only

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recall the single line of pain, and after all, what does it matter? What matters here is that I'm alive and they don't know it.

The clank is followed by a sound that scares me badly: steel instruments clicking together. They are off to the left of me, and although I can't see them, I know what they're getting ready to do: the autopsy. They are getting ready to cut into me. They intend to remove [my] heart and see if it blew a piston.

My leg! I scream inside my head. ***Look at my left leg! That's the trouble, not my heart!***

The scissors have long, sharp blades, very sharp blades, and fat slides into the but like butter. Then, snip, up through the bundle of nerves at the solar plexus and into the beef jerky weave of muscle and tendons above it. Then into the sternum. When the blades come together this time, they do so with a heavy crunch as the bone parts and the rib cage pops apart.

They're going to do it. I have to make some kind of noise or movement, or they're really going to do it. If blood flows or jets up from the first punch of scissors

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they'll know something's wrong, but by then it will be too late.

I concentrate everything on my chest. I push, or try to… and something happens. A sound! I make a sound! It's mostly inside my closed mouth, but I can also hear and feel it in my nose- a low hum.

I am lifted. Then I am laid flat again and my shirt is gone. I'm now naked to the waist. It's cold in the room.

Look at my chest! I scream. ***You must see it rise and fall, no matter how shallow my respiration is! You're an expert, for Christ's sake!***

PATHOLOGIST: Do you want to handle temp and gross examination?

PETER: Hey, as long as you'll cover for me if…

PATHOLOGIST: Sure. Got to get your feet wet sometime, Peter. And if you really need me to, I'll roll the tape back.

PETER: You can do that?

HOWARD: Surely they won't really cut me up will they? Pete is no veteran, but he has had some training; surely he'll see the marks of whatever bit me while I was

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looking for my ball in the rough, and then they'll at least suspect. They'll have to suspect.

PETER: Ready, doctor.

HOWARD: Somewhere, tape is rolling. The autopsy procedure has begun.

PETER: Subject is a white Caucasian, age forty-four. His name is Howard Randolph Cottrell, residence is 1566 Laurel Crest Lane. Cause of death may be a heart attack. No neck injury apparent, no rigor. No wounds visible on the back or buttocks, although there's an old scar on the upper right thigh that looks like some sort of wound, shrapnel, perhaps. It's an ugly one. *(taking the body temperature)* 94.2. Gee, that ain't too shabby. This guy could almost be alive.

PATHOLOGIST: They found him in the rough. At a guess, he had a heart attack while he was looking for his ball. Keep going, Peter, you're doing fine.

PETER: *(continuing the external exam)* There are mosquito bites on the left calf that look infected.

HOWARD: I focus all my will and effort on closing my eyes while he's looking down onto my face, and cannot

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produce even a tic. All I wanted was eighteen holes of golf on a Saturday afternoon, and instead I turned into Snow White with hair on my chest. And I can't stop wondering what it's going to feel like when those poultry shears go sliding into my midsection.

PETER: I am commencing the autopsy at 5:49 P.M. Saturday, August 20th, 1994.

HOWARD: He lifts my lips, looks at my teeth like a man thinking about buying a horse, then pulls my jaw down.

PETER: Good color and no petechiae on the cheeks… man this guy really could still be alive!

PATHOLOGIST: *(laughing)* Doesn't he wish.

HOWARD: This time it's cancer I wish on them, some kind that is inoperable and lasts a long time. *(Burp)* He looks at me, eyes widening, mouth dropped a little, and again I try desperately to hum, knowing he won't hear it but thinking that maybe, along with the burp, he'll finally be ready to see what's right in front of him…

PATHOLOGIST: *(chuckling)* Excuse yourself, Howie.

HOWARD: Now I'm trying to stick out my tongue. Just that simple kid's gesture of impudence, but it would be

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enough… and it seems to me I can feel a faint prickling sensation deep within my lips, the feeling you get when you're finally starting to come out of a heavy dose of Novocain. And I can feel a twitch? No, wishful thinking, just… Yes! Yes! But a twitch is all, and the second time I try, nothing happens.

Pete turns the scissors at an angle so the light runs down the blade, and for the first time I'm certain, really certain that this mad charade is going to go all the way through the end. The director isn't going to freeze the frame. The ref isn't going to stop the fight in the tenth round. Petie boy's going to slide those scissors into my gut while I lie here helpless, and then he's going to open me up like a mail order package.

No! I howl, my voice reverberating off the dark walls of my skull but emerging from my mouth not at all. **No please no!** I try to make the humming noise and discover a horrid thing: now I can't even to that. I'm too scared. Fright has locked down my vocal cords. I can only stare. He slowly brings them out. I see them… then

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they're gone from my field of vision. A long moment later, I feel a steel nestle again my naked upper belly.

PETER: Are you sure you don't…

PATHOLOGIST: Do you want to make this your field or not, Peter?

HOWARD: The door bursts open. Pete cries out in surprise.

AMBULANCE DRIVER: *(frantically)* Don't cut him up! Don't cut him up, there was a snake in his golf bag and it bit Mike knocking him flat! He's gonna be okay, I guess, but he can hardly talk! Little brown snake, I never saw one like it in my life, it went under the loadin' bay, it's under there now, but that's not the important part! I think… holy shit doc, watcha tryin' to do? Stoke him back to life?"

HOWARD: [The pathologist] looks around, dazed, at first not sure of what he's talking about. And as she screams, screams and snatches the shears out of Pete's limp gloved hand… I find myself thinking again of that old Alfred Hitchcock TV show. Poor old Joseph Cotton, I think. He only got to cry.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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Watch Alfred Hitchcock's "Breakdown" here
https://the.hitchcock.zone/wiki/Alfred_Hitchcock_Presents_-_Breakdown

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